

Recognizing Coercive Control

Naming the grip, to free yourself from it

4 psychology approaches · tips & resources — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Naming the grip, to free yourself from it

Coercive control is a grip that sets in step by step: isolation from loved ones, surveillance, control of money or outings, put-downs, veiled threats. There may be no blows — and that's exactly what makes it hard to name. Yet it's a recognized form of violence.

This guide helps you recognize the mechanisms, understand why it's so hard to leave, and rebuild your support — at your pace, and never alone.

Your intention

What, in your relationship, makes you feel controlled or diminished: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Why the grip is hard to see

The grip sets in slowly, alternating tension and reconciliation, playing on your attachment and your hope that 'it'll get better'. That's what makes it so hard to recognize from inside.

Not having seen it right away is neither weakness nor your fault.

Example

Camille thought it 'normal' to justify every outing. Laying out the timeline, she saw how much her freedom had shrunk.

The timeline

How have things changed since the relationship began? Note the stages.

What I no longer allow myself

List what you stopped doing (seeing loved ones, spending, going out) — and who really decided it.

→ *The grip sets in slowly — not seeing it isn't a fault.*

The thoughts the grip installs

'It's my fault', 'I'm exaggerating', 'without them I'm nothing': these thoughts weren't yours at first — they were installed, through repetition.

Testing them against the facts you note restores your clarity.

Example

Sure she was 'exaggerating', Inès reread her notes of facts. The reality was there, in black and white.

Facts journal

Note the facts, without minimizing (date · what happened · how I felt).

Reframe

Turn 'I'm exaggerating' into 'here are the facts I noted'.

→ *These aren't my flaws — they're their control mechanisms.*

Reconnecting with yourself

The grip smothers your feelings, needs, and desires. Reconnecting with who you are — your tastes, your bonds, your plans — is an act of resistance.

Your worth hasn't vanished: it's been covered over.

Example

Recalling what she loved 'before', Léa felt a part of herself she thought lost begin to return.

Who I was before

Write: my tastes, my bonds, my plans, before this relationship.

My smothered needs

Which needs did you set aside? Which could you honor, even a little?

→ *My feelings are valid — I can trust them again.*

Rebuilding support & protecting yourself

Breaking the isolation is the key: a trusted person, a specialized service that can help you see clearly AND plan safely. You decide the pace — you don't have to do it all at once.

Asking for help isn't a failure: it's protection.

Example

Simply calling a helpline let Sofia understand she was neither crazy nor alone.

My circle of trust

Whom can I reconnect with (a loved one, a colleague, a service)?

One safe first step

One safe step this week (a call, a message to a helpline).

→ *Breaking the isolation, safely, is the first key.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- The grip isn't love, even without blows.
- Note the facts in a safe place (not on a device that may be monitored).
- Reconnect, even discreetly, with a trusted person.
- A specialized service can help you see clearly AND plan your safety.
- You don't have to decide everything at once — one step at a time.
- It's not your fault. In immediate danger, call emergency services.

To fill in

Facts journal

Date	What happened	How I felt

My support plan

Trusted person / service	My next safe step

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Lay out the timeline of the grip.

Week 2 — Test the installed thoughts against facts.

Week 3 — Reconnect with who I am.

Week 4 — Break the isolation, safely.

Your plan in 3 lines

- What I stopped allowing myself:
- The fact I refuse to minimize:
- The person or service I contact:

TO CLOSE

Naming the grip is the start of freeing yourself — at your pace, never alone.

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This guide helps you recognize and name what you're living: it's a psychoeducation tool, not therapy or legal advice. If you're in immediate danger, call your local emergency number. To be heard and guided, reach out to a domestic-abuse or victim-support helpline in your country — most are free and confidential. You're not alone, and none of this is your fault. ©

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